The Exact Spot

Texas, the Mexican-American War, and the Question It Reopened

15 MINUTE HISTORY · NARRATION SCRIPT · 2,474 WORDS · ABOUT 13:52

> ***Driving question:*** *How did a fight over a strip of land between two rivers become a war that cost Mexico half its land? And why did winning that war make America's biggest problem worse?*

Underlined = vocabulary card on screen · *italic* = spoken with emphasis · timestamps are estimates until the voice is recorded

0:00 The Exact Spot

December 22nd, 1847. A brand-new congressman from Illinois stands up in the House. He's 38 years old. His name is Abraham Lincoln.

And he has a question for the President. Eight questions, actually, all written down. But they boil down to one: *where is the spot?*

A year and a half earlier, President James K. Polk had asked Congress for a war with Mexico. Mexico, he said, had "shed American blood upon the American soil."

Lincoln wants to know which soil. Because if that blood was shed on Mexican land, the whole story changes.

So look at Texas. Two rivers. The Nueces, up here. The Rio Grande, about 150 miles south. Texas said its border was the Rio Grande. Mexico said Texas stopped at the Nueces.

So here's the question I want to answer today: How did a fight over a strip of land between two rivers become a war that cost Mexico half its land? And why did winning that war make America's biggest problem worse?

It starts with Mexico inviting Americans in.

1:06 Come On In

1821. Mexico wins its independence from Spain, and inherits a huge northern frontier called Texas.

The Comanche and other Native nations live there. But Mexico's own settlers, the **Tejanos**, Mexican Texans, number only a few thousand. So Mexico has an idea. Invite people in. Give them cheap land, and they'll farm it and help defend it.

Americans jump at the deal. Stephen F. Austin, an **empresario**, a contractor paid in land for bringing in settlers, brings the first 300 families. The rules: become a Mexican citizen, follow Mexican law, and become Catholic.

Many of the settlers come from the South to grow cotton. And they bring enslaved people with them.

By the early 1830s, Americans in Texas outnumber Tejanos many times over. Mexico's plan worked. A little too well.

So Mexico tries to slow things down. In 1829, it *abolishes slavery*. Texas talks its way into an exception.

In 1830, Mexico bans new American settlers and new enslaved people, and sends soldiers to collect new taxes on imports. Americans keep coming anyway.

2:04 Come and Take It

So why did Texas break away? Let's look at the evidence.

Texas didn't have its own state. Mexico had joined it to a bigger one, Coahuila, with a capital hundreds of miles away. Laws were written in Spanish. There were no jury trials. Only one religion was allowed.

In 1833, Austin goes to Mexico City to ask for a separate state. He ends up in jail, and doesn't make it home for more than two years.

Meanwhile, General Antonio López de Santa Anna takes charge of Mexico. He throws out the federal constitution and moves power to the capital. That's **centralism**: the national government decides, not the states.

October 1835. Gonzales, Texas. Mexican soldiers come to take back a small cannon. The settlers make a flag: a cannon, a star, and three words. "Come and take it." Shots are fired. The revolution is on.

March 2nd, 1836. Texas delegates declare independence. Their declaration lists Mexico's wrongs: no jury trials, no public schools, and a government that demanded their weapons and threw out their constitution.

Three of the signers were Mexican-born, including José Antonio Navarro of San Antonio. This wasn't only an American fight.

But here's what the declaration *doesn't* mention. Slavery. Not once.

Two weeks later, the same delegates write a constitution. And it protects slavery. Their congress can never free anyone who is enslaved. Free Black people can't even live in Texas without permission.

So was the Texas Revolution about freedom, or about slavery? To the settlers, it was a fight against a dictator for rights they'd been promised. The constitution shows what else they meant to protect. Freedom for some Texans. Slavery for others. *Both, at once.*

3:36 Remember the Alamo

Santa Anna marches north with thousands of soldiers.

February 1836. About 200 Texans dig in at an old mission in San Antonio called the Alamo. One of them is a Tejano captain, Juan Seguín. He's sent out to ride for help. Remember him.

March 6th, before dawn, Santa Anna attacks. In about 90 minutes, nearly all the defenders are dead. Three weeks later, at Goliad, he orders more

than 300 Texan prisoners shot.

April 21st. San Jacinto. Sam Houston's army catches Santa Anna's camp off guard. The battle lasts about 18 minutes. The next day, Texans find a man hiding in the marsh grass, dressed as a private. Then the Mexican prisoners see him and call out, "El Presidente!" It's Santa Anna.

To win his freedom, Santa Anna signs a treaty. Mexico's government rejects it. As far as Mexico is concerned, Texas is still Mexico. Hold that thought.

And the new Republic of Texas says its border is the Rio Grande, even though Texas had stopped at the Nueces. That strip in between? That's where Lincoln's spot will be.

For nine years, Texas is its own country, with slavery written into its laws. It asks to join the United States right away. But a big new slave state would start a fight in Congress, and maybe a war with Mexico. So: not yet.

In 1845, Congress finally **annexes** Texas, adding it to the United States. Mexico breaks off relations.

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5:04 Polk Acts First

Meet the new president, James K. Polk. He wants California, and its great harbor at San Francisco.

In 1845, a magazine editor names an idea lots of Americans already hold: **Manifest Destiny**, the belief that the United States was meant, even chosen by God, to spread across the whole continent. To believers, that meant farms, towns and self-government moving west. To the Mexicans

and Native nations already there, it meant someone else had decided their land was America's future.

Polk tries to buy it first. He sends a diplomat to Mexico City with an offer of up to 25 million dollars for California and New Mexico. Mexico won't even meet him. To Mexico, the U.S. had just taken Texas. Now it wanted more.

So in January 1846, Polk orders General Zachary Taylor's army to the Rio Grande. Straight into the land between the rivers. Mexico's commander tells Taylor to leave. He doesn't.

April 25th. Mexican cavalry surround an American patrol. More than a dozen Americans are killed or wounded, and most of the rest are captured.

In 1846, news travels at the speed of a horse. It takes about two weeks to reach Washington.

And on May 9th, before it arrives, Polk's cabinet agrees he should ask Congress for war anyway. That same evening, the news arrives. Polk's own diary records it all.

Two days later, Polk tells Congress that Mexico has "shed American blood upon the American soil." The bill says a war *already exists*, "by the act of the Republic of Mexico."

Some members doubt that. But voting no could look like abandoning soldiers under fire. So on May 13th, 1846, Congress declares war, by a huge margin.

So who decided this country would go to war? Congress declared it. But the President put the army where a fight was likely, and *Congress voted after the shooting started.*

6:46 Plot Twists

The war moves fast. And it comes with a plot twist.

When the war starts, Santa Anna isn't even in Mexico. He's in exile in Cuba. So he sends Polk a message: let me through your navy's blockade, and I'll make you a deal. Polk says yes. The U.S. Navy lets him sail right past. Santa Anna lands, takes command of Mexico's army, and fights the United States for the rest of the war.

So much for the deal.

Santa Anna, by the way, has only one leg. He lost the other fighting the French in 1838, and later gave it a state funeral. A few years after that, an angry crowd dug it up. Then in 1847, soldiers from Illinois captured his cork leg on the battlefield. It's still in a museum in Springfield, Illinois. Mexico has asked for it back.

Meanwhile, the Americans push in from three directions. Taylor wins in the north and becomes a national hero. American forces take New Mexico, and after hard fighting with the Californios, Mexican Californians, California too. And General Winfield Scott lands at Veracruz and marches on Mexico City.

September 13th, 1847. Scott's army storms the castle of Chapultepec. Mexico still honors six teenage cadets who died there: the Niños Héroes, the boy heroes.

That same morning, a few miles away, 30 men stand on wagons with nooses around their necks. They're San Patricios: mostly Irish Catholic immigrants who had deserted the American army to fight for Mexico. The American colonel makes them wait, watching the castle, until the U.S. flag goes up over Chapultepec. Then they're hanged.

The next day, Americans march into Mexico City.

Some of the young American officers: Ulysses S. Grant. Robert E. Lee. Stonewall Jackson. In about 14 years, they'll be fighting each other.

8:24 The Spot

Which brings us back to Lincoln. December 1847. The war is basically won, and he asks: was the spot really American soil?

He had a point. That fight happened in the strip between the rivers. Land Texas claimed, but had never really governed.

And he wasn't alone. Less than two weeks later, the House votes, 85 to 81, that the war was "unnecessarily and unconstitutionally begun by the President." While it's still going on. Awkward.

Lincoln pays for it. Papers back home call him "Spotty Lincoln." He serves his one term and goes home.

And a young officer who fought in the war, Ulysses S. Grant, later called it "one of the most unjust ever waged by a stronger against a weaker nation."

But supporters saw it differently. Mexico had refused to negotiate. It had stopped paying money it owed American citizens. Its soldiers fired first, in land Texas claimed. And Manifest Destiny said this land was America's future anyway. In much of the country, the war was popular.

So was it defense, or conquest? Historians have argued about that for more than a century. Some blame Mexico. Others blame Polk. The evidence gives each side something to hold onto.

9:31 The Man Who Was Fired

Now Polk needs a peace treaty. He sends a diplomat, Nicholas Trist. The talks drag on, and Polk orders him home.

Trist says no. Mexico finally has leaders ready to make peace, and if he leaves, the chance is gone. So he writes Polk a letter explaining why. It's 65 pages long. Which is a very long way to say no.

February 2nd, 1848. Trist signs the **Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo**. A peace treaty, signed by a man who technically doesn't work for the government anymore.

Polk calls him a "scoundrel" in his diary. But it's the deal he wanted, and the Senate approves it. Trist doesn't get paid until 1871.

The deal: the Rio Grande is the border of Texas. And Mexico hands over the **Mexican Cession**, about 530,000 square miles. Today that's California, Nevada, Utah, and most of the Southwest. Counting Texas, Mexico lost about half its land. The United States pays 15 million dollars.

And here's what nobody at the table knew. Nine days earlier, a carpenter in California had found gold.

The treaty makes promises to the people already living there. Article 8 says their property will be "inviolably respected," and they can become citizens. But the Senate cuts Article 10, which protected their land grants. Hold that thought.

10:41 Who Paid

So who paid for all this?

About 1,700 Americans were killed in battle. More than 11,500 died of disease: dysentery, yellow fever, measles. For every soldier killed in battle, nearly 7 died of sickness.

Mexico's losses were larger. No one counted them all.

About 80,000 Mexicans lived in the Mexican Cession. They didn't move. The border did.

On paper, their property was protected. But in 1851, Congress made landowners in California prove their titles in court. Many cases took more than 15 years. Lawyers' fees and squatters took much of the land anyway.

Native nations weren't part of the treaty at all. No one asked them. In Texas, tens of thousands of enslaved people were now held in an

American state. No one asked them either.

And Juan Seguín, the Tejano who rode out of the Alamo for help? He became mayor of San Antonio. Then newer Anglo settlers accused him of siding with Mexico, and drove him out. Under pressure, he ended up fighting for Mexico.

Years later, he called himself "a foreigner in my native land."

11:46 Poison

Now back to August 1846, three months into the war. Polk asks Congress for money to buy land from Mexico. And a congressman from Pennsylvania, David Wilmot, adds one sentence to the bill.

No slavery in any land taken from Mexico. That's the **Wilmot Proviso**. A proviso is a condition attached to a law.

Wilmot wasn't an abolitionist. He said he wanted the land kept for free white workers. But his sentence asked the question Washington had been avoiding.

It passes the House, 83 to 64. It dies in the Senate. It comes back again and again, and it *never becomes law*.

But look at the vote. Almost every yes came from the North. Almost every no came from the South. Both big parties of the day, the Democrats and the Whigs, split the same way. That's **sectionalism**: loyalty to your region over your party.

Here's why winning made it harder. Texas was already a slave state when it joined. This land was new. Every acre forced the question: slave, or free?

In 1846, the writer Ralph Waldo Emerson saw it coming. "The United States will conquer Mexico," he wrote, "but it will be as the man swallows the arsenic, which brings him down in turn. Mexico will poison us."

So, back to Lincoln's question. Where was the spot? In land both countries claimed. To supporters, Mexico attacked first, and America claimed its destiny. To critics, a president sent an army into disputed land and got the war he wanted. Both readings were there from the start.

But the bigger question was never where the war started. It was what the new land would become.

Remember those young officers? April 1865. Two of them meet at Appomattox, Virginia. Robert E. Lee is surrendering his army to Ulysses S. Grant. And for a while, they talk about Mexico, back when they were on the same side. Grant wrote that the talk got so pleasant, he almost forgot why they were there.

Grant also wrote that the Civil War was "largely the outgrowth of the Mexican war."

Emerson had warned that Mexico would poison the country that conquered it.

It took about 13 years to work.

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